Chapter-wise Detailed Notes — Democracy: meaning, forms, characteristics, merits, demerits and preconditions

Introduction to Political Theory · Unit 2 · Chapter Democracy: meaning, forms, characteristics, merits, demerits and preconditions

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Chapter Study Notes

Learning focus

Democracy is a system in which political authority is grounded in the people and public power is subject to participation, accountability and meaningful political competition.

1. Direct democracy involves citizens deciding issues themselves; representative democracy relies on elected representatives. Liberal democracy combines elections with rights, rule of law and institutional checks.

2. Common characteristics include universal political participation, periodic elections, pluralism, freedom of expression, accountable government and protection of opposition.

3. Advantages include legitimacy, peaceful transfers of power and channels for participation. Risks include majoritarianism, misinformation, short-termism and unequal influence.

4. Democracy is strengthened by civic education, independent institutions, fair elections, access to information, social inclusion and protection of minority rights.

Revision checklist

■ Can I define the key concept in my own words?

■ Can I explain its main features and distinguish it from related concepts?

■ Can I support an argument with a relevant example, thinker or constitutional provision?

■ Can I discuss at least one limitation or counterargument?